

TNTP CORE TEACHING RUBRIC

A TOOL FOR CONDUCTING COMMON CORE-ALIGNED CLASSROOM OBSERVATIONS

Thank you for your interest in the TNTP Core Teaching Rubric! TNTP Core describes excellent instruction aligned to the Common Core, and provides a common language to articulate what it looks like in practice. Even in schools and districts not adopting Common Core standards, this short but comprehensive tool can train focus on the essential components of instruction that can be identified in a classroom observation. By rating only four performance areas, TNTP Core allows observers and teachers to [focus on feedback and development](#). It is not a comprehensive evaluation system, but should be one of [multiple measures of performance](#).

Schools are encouraged to pilot this rubric and customize the language to fit local context. Consider the following guidance:

- To maintain focus, we don't recommend adding more than one additional performance area.
- The current selection of Core Teacher Skills was developed based on TNTP's experience training and developing teachers. Be flexible in adding and adjusting the Core Teacher Skills, and encourage observers and teachers to create their own additions in the field. After observers and teachers agree on a Core Teacher Skill to focus on, they should then discuss and agree on the specific and bite-sized action that the teacher will take within the next week.

Even the best rubric will fail to help teachers develop if it is not implemented with care. Thoughtful introduction and deliberate training with ongoing practice will ensure that all stakeholders share an understanding of the rubric's meaning and use. Principals, coaches and teachers should all be well trained on the rubric and its use, and have opportunities to practice observing instruction together to ensure consistent, accurate ratings.

Take what you learn from a pilot to inform ongoing training and norming. And please tell us what you learn, at info@tntp.org.

If your school or district needs support or advice in training or norming, please feel free to contact us at info@tntp.org.

The TNTP Core Teaching Rubric is used to describe and assess teacher performance across four performance areas:

- **STUDENT ENGAGEMENT:** Are all students engaged in the work of the lesson from start to finish?
- **ESSENTIAL CONTENT:** Are all students working with content aligned to the appropriate standards for their subject and grade?
- **ACADEMIC OWNERSHIP:** Are all students responsible for doing the thinking in this classroom?
- **DEMONSTRATION OF LEARNING:** Do all students demonstrate that they are learning?

Each performance area has three components:

1. **Essential Question:** The core question to answer about the particular performance area. In an effective teacher's classroom, the answer to each Essential Question is "yes."
2. **Descriptor Language:** Descriptions of the essence of each performance area, used to differentiate four levels of performance: Effective, Developing, Minimally Effective, and Ineffective. The TNTP Core Teaching Rubric uses descriptors that focus primarily on student actions and responses.
3. **Core Teacher Skills:** A non-exhaustive list of the teacher skills and behaviors that contribute to the student outcomes in each performance area. After observing and rating a lesson, we recommend that you select or identify one or two Core Teacher Skills to prioritize for the next development cycle.

When observers use the TNTP Core Teaching Rubric, they select the rating where the combination of descriptors most closely describes the observed performance, using a preponderance of evidence for each performance area. Observers do not rate the teacher on Core Teacher Skills; those are included only for coaching and development purposes. The Core Teacher Skills can help an observer narrow in on development areas based on ratings in performance areas, and guide conversations about specific strategies teachers can use to develop and grow.



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STUDENT ENGAGEMENT | Are all students engaged in the work of the lesson from start to finish?

INEFFECTIVE	MINIMALLY EFFECTIVE	DEVELOPING	EFFECTIVE
Engagement: Very few or no* students complete instructional tasks, volunteer responses and/or ask appropriate questions. Expectations: Very few or no students demonstrate a clear understanding of behavioral expectations and directions through their actions. Procedures: Students do not execute transitions, routines and procedures in an orderly manner. Students are left without work to do for a significant portion of the class period.	Engagement: Some** students complete instructional tasks, volunteer responses and/or ask appropriate questions. Expectations: Some students demonstrate a clear understanding of behavioral expectations and directions. Procedures: Students sometimes execute transitions, routines and procedures in an orderly and efficient manner and/or require substantial direction or narration. Students are idle while waiting for the teacher or left with nothing to do for one or two minutes at a time.	Engagement: Most*** students complete instructional tasks, volunteer responses and/or ask appropriate questions. Expectations: Most students demonstrate a clear understanding of behavioral expectations and directions. Procedures: Students mostly execute transitions, routines and procedures in an orderly and efficient manner, though they may require some direction or narration. Students are only idle for short periods of time (less than one minute at a time).	Engagement: All or almost all**** students complete instructional tasks, volunteer responses and/or ask appropriate questions. Expectations: All or almost all students are self-directed to follow behavioral expectations and directions. Procedures: Students assume responsibility for routines and procedures and execute them in an orderly, efficient and self-directed manner, requiring little or no direction or narration. Students who finish assigned work early engage in meaningful learning without interrupting other students' learning.
* Very few/no: 0-25%	**Some: 25-60%	***Most: 60-85%	****All/almost all: 85-100%

Core Teacher Skills

Maintaining High Behavior Expectations

- Providing specific, concrete, sequential, and observable directions for behavior and academics
- Addressing all negative and off-task student behavior immediately and in a way that does not slow or disrupt lesson momentum
- Issuing logical and appropriate consequences as needed without hesitation, such that consequences are successful in changing student behavior
- Using voice and presence to maintain authority and convey caring for students
- Investing time in knowing individual students and in forming relationships to best support their learning
- Developing an active interest in students' well-being and demonstrating that interest through his/her engagement with students
- Developing and implementing a positive behavior intervention system
- Developing student ownership for a respectful, clean and organized classroom that is conducive to student learning

Maximizing Instructional Time

- Using efficient routines and procedures
- Responding to student requests without interrupting instruction

ESSENTIAL CONTENT | Are all students working with content aligned to the appropriate standards for their subject and grade?

Note to observers: When assessing the content of the lesson, your goal is to first examine what students are being asked to do during the lesson, and with what materials. Then, compare this to the expectation of the relevant Common Core or state standard for that particular subject/grade to assess whether or not the students are working with appropriately rigorous content.

INEFFECTIVE	MINIMALLY EFFECTIVE	DEVELOPING	EFFECTIVE
Content: The lesson does not* focus on content that advances students toward grade-level standards or expectations and/or IEP goals. Lesson Activities: Most of the activities students engage in are not aligned to the stated or implied learning goal(s) or to each other. Sequence: Most activities students engage in are disconnected from one another and/or do not move students toward mastery of the standard(s). Materials: Instructional materials students use are not appropriately demanding for the grade/course and time in the school-year, based on the standards and/or students' IEP goals (ex. Lexile level and complexity of text).	Content: The lesson partially** focuses on content that advances students toward grade-level standards or expectations and/or IEP goals. Lesson Activities: Only some activities students engage in are aligned to the stated or implied learning goal(s). Sequence: Some activities students engage in are disconnected from one another and/or do not move students toward mastery of the standard(s). Materials: Some instructional materials students use are not appropriately demanding for the grade/course and time in the school-year, based on the standards and/or students' IEP goals (ex. Lexile level and complexity of text).	Content: The lesson focuses on content that advances students toward grade-level standards or expectations and/or IEP goals. Lesson Activities: Most*** activities students engage in are aligned to the stated or implied learning goal(s) and move students toward mastery of the grade-level standard(s) and/or IEP goal(s). Sequence: Most activities students engage in are generally connected to one another and move students toward mastery of the standard(s). Materials: Most instructional materials students use are appropriately demanding for the grade/course and time in the school-year, based on the standards and/or students' IEP goals (ex. Lexile level and complexity of text).	Content: The lesson focuses on content that advances students toward grade-level standards or expectations and/or IEP goals and aligns to the big ideas of the unit. Lesson Activities: All**** activities students engage in are aligned to the stated or implied learning goal(s) and are well-sequenced and build on each other to move students toward mastery of the grade-level standard(s) and/or IEP goals. Sequence: All activities students engage in are well-sequenced and build on each other to move students toward mastery of the standard(s). Materials: All instructional materials students use are high-quality and appropriately demanding for the grade/course and time in the school-year, based on the standards and/or students' IEP goals (ex. Lexile level and complexity of text). Connections: Students have the opportunity to make connections between what they are learning and content within/across disciplines.

*Do(es) not/are not: 0-25%

**Partially/some: 25-60%

***Most: 60-85%

****All/ almost all: 85-100%

Core Teacher Skills

Planning Effectively

- Allocating instructional time to address the most important content for the grade or course and big ideas for the unit
- Using student data to develop and clearly communicate a well-framed, standards-aligned and appropriately rigorous objective to describe the goal(s) of the lesson
- Developing and/or using a variety of appropriately demanding instructional materials and activities, such as texts, questions, problems, exercises and assessments
- Developing a vision for student success and standards-aligned, big goal(s) that are ambitious, measurable and appropriate for all students
- Developing and/or using a long-term, sequential plan that leads to mastery of the most important content for the grade or course
- Developing and/or using daily lesson activities that are well sequenced, aligned to key points and move students toward mastery of grade-level standards
- Developing, providing and executing accommodations and modifications based on student data to ensure all students are able to attain learning goals
- Considering students' IEP goals and other specific learning needs in developing learning goals and preparing lessons (where applicable)
- Anticipating common student misunderstandings given the content, and ensuring strategies are in place to overcome those misunderstandings
- Planning for and providing work for students to "say yes to" and using strategies to maintain a quick pace throughout the lesson
- Developing lessons using backwards planning aligned to the scope and sequence and network assessments
- Collaborating with other teachers and/or grade level teams to develop cross-content lessons, questions and activities with a focus on CCSS in reading, writing and speaking

ACADEMIC OWNERSHIP | Are all students responsible for doing the thinking in this classroom?

INEFFECTIVE	MINIMALLY EFFECTIVE	DEVELOPING	EFFECTIVE
Evidence: Very few or no* students provide meaningful oral or written evidence to support their thinking. Cognitive Work: Students complete very little of the cognitive work during the lesson, such as reading, writing, discussion, analysis, computation, or problem solving; the teacher completes all or almost all of the cognitive work. Discourse: Very few or no students respond to their peers' thinking, ideas, or answers. Perseverance: No students or very few students try hard to complete academic work or answer questions.	Evidence: Very few or no* students provide meaningful oral or written evidence to support their thinking. Cognitive Work: Students complete some of the cognitive work during the lesson, such as reading, writing, discussion, analysis, computation, or problem solving, but the teacher or a very small number of students complete most of the cognitive work. Discourse: Some students respond to their peers' thinking, ideas or answers and/or provide feedback to their classmates. Perseverance: Some students try hard to complete challenging academic work and answer questions.	Evidence: Most*** students provide meaningful oral or written evidence to support their thinking. Cognitive Work: Students complete an appropriately challenging amount of the cognitive work during the lesson, such as reading, writing, discussion, analysis, computation, or problem solving, given the focus of the lesson, and most of the students complete the cognitive work. Discourse: Most students respond to their peers' thinking, ideas or answers and provide feedback to their classmates. Perseverance: Most students try hard to complete academic work and answer questions, even if the work is challenging.	Evidence: All or almost all**** students provide meaningful oral or written evidence to support their thinking. Cognitive Work: Students complete an appropriately challenging amount of the cognitive work during the lesson, such as reading, writing, discussion, analysis, computation, or problem solving, given the focus of the lesson, and all or almost all of the students complete the cognitive work. Discourse: All or almost all students routinely provide constructive feedback to their classmates and respond productively when a peer answers a question incorrectly or when they do not agree with their peers' thinking, ideas or answers. Perseverance: All or almost all students consistently try hard to complete academic work and answer questions, even if the work is challenging.
*Very few/no: 0-25%	**Some: 25-60%	***Most: 60-85%	****All/almost all: 85-100%

Core Teacher Skills

Maintaining High Academic Expectations

- Promoting student persistence to get correct, defended responses
- Connecting learning to student performance and long-term outcomes and investing students in their progress
- Requiring that students use complete sentences, correct grammar and academic language

Building Thinking Skills

- Structuring and delivering lesson activities so that students do an appropriate amount of the thinking required by the lesson
- Designing lessons that include multiple ways for students to support their thinking, including writing, reading, speaking, and student discourse
- Posing questions or providing lesson activities that require students to cite evidence to support their thinking
- Providing opportunities for students to respond to and build on their peers' ideas
- Providing support necessary for students to complete instructional tasks requiring higher-order thinking skills
- Providing individualized instruction so that all students can access content and participate in the class

DEMONSTRATION OF LEARNING | Do all students demonstrate that they are learning?

INEFFECTIVE	MINIMALLY EFFECTIVE	DEVELOPING	EFFECTIVE
Checks for Understanding: Questions, tasks or assessments do not* yield data that allow the teacher to assess students' progress toward learning goals. Opportunity: Students have very few or no opportunities to express learning through academic writing and/or explanations using academic language. Student Understanding: Very few or no students demonstrate how well they understand lesson content and their progress toward learning goals. Practice: Student responses, work and interactions demonstrate that most students are not on track to achieve learning goals. Data Tracking: Very few or no students monitor their own progress, identify their own errors, and seek additional opportunities for practice.	Checks for Understanding: Questions, tasks or assessments yield data that only partially** allow the teacher to assess students' progress toward learning goals. Opportunity: Students have few opportunities to express learning through academic writing and/or explanations using academic language. Student Understanding: Some students demonstrate how well they understand lesson content and their progress toward learning goals through their work and/or responses. Practice: Student responses, work and interactions demonstrate that some students are on track to achieve learning goals. Data Tracking: Some students monitor their own progress, identify their own errors, and seek additional opportunities for practice.	Checks for Understanding: Questions, tasks or assessments yield data that allow the teacher to assess students' progress toward learning goals and to sometimes make adjustments in instruction. Opportunity: Students have some*** opportunities to express learning through academic writing and/or explanations using academic language. Student Understanding: Most students demonstrate how well they understand lesson content and their progress toward learning goals through their work and/or responses. Practice: Student responses, work and interactions demonstrate that most students are on track to achieve learning goals. Data Tracking: Most students monitor their own progress, identify their own errors, and seek additional opportunities for practice.	Checks for Understanding: Questions, tasks or assessments yield data that allow the teacher to assess students' progress toward learning goals and to regularly**** make adjustments in instruction. Opportunity: Students have extensive opportunities to express learning through academic writing and/or explanations using academic language. Student Understanding: All students demonstrate how well they understand lesson content and their progress toward learning goals through their work and/or responses. Practice: Student responses, work and interactions demonstrate that all or almost all students are on track to achieve learning goals. Data Tracking: All or almost all students monitor their own progress, identify their own errors, and seek additional opportunities for practice.
<i>*Do not/very few/no: 0-25%</i>	<i>**Partially/few/some: 25-60%</i>	<i>***Some/most: 60-85%</i>	<i>****Regularly/all/almost all: 85-100%</i>

Core Teacher Skills

Leading Instruction

- Conveying or providing accurate content and all content necessary for students to achieve the learning goal(s)
- Using explanations of content that are clear, coherent and support student understanding of content
- Differentiating instruction as needed in response to student learning needs, including enrichment and extra support
- Developing and using visuals and/or demonstrations to clarify key points in the lesson

Checking for Understanding of Content

- Planning for and accurately checking whether students understand the key content needed to master the lesson at key moments in the lesson (e.g. during direct instruction, before independent practice, at a transition and with an exit ticket at the end of a lesson)
- Developing and/or using informal and formal assessments that yield useable data on students' progress toward grade-level standards
- Planning multiple opportunities for students to practice the skills they are expected to master in the lesson

Responding to Student Misunderstanding

- Providing feedback that affirms correctly understood content and student progress toward the lesson objective, and clarifies misunderstood content
- Planning for and recognizing the root of student errors and re-teaching or re-framing content to address the underlying cause of student misunderstanding
- Adjusting instruction in the moment to address student misunderstanding and using assessments to adjustment instruction as needed

TNTP Core Classroom Walk-Through Tool

The TNTP Core Walk-Through Tool is a companion to the full TNTP Core Teaching Rubric and is aligned to the same vital performance areas. This tool can be used alone to guide peer-to-peer feedback, personal reflection and non-evaluative coaching. Observers who have experience with the TNTP Core Teaching Rubric may also use the Walk-Through Tool as a note-taking and feedback resource for all classroom observations.

When you visit a classroom, ask yourself the four Essential Questions and record your notes and/or evidence in the box below.

1. Are all students engaged in the work of the lesson from start to finish?

RATING: _____

2. Are all students working with content aligned to the appropriate standards for their subject and grade?

RATING: _____

What did you see students doing, reading and working with? What work do the grade-level standards call for?

3. Are all students responsible for doing the thinking in this classroom?

RATING: _____

4. Do all students demonstrate that they are learning?

RATING: _____

Follow-up Questions

What's keeping you from answering 'yes' to all four Essential Questions above?

What specific skill or technique will you and the teacher practice and develop over the next cycle?